Chapter 1 — The LLD Interview & How to Approach It (Study Edition)

> **Study Edition.** Every topic of the full chapter, without the padding. Full code, outputs and extra examples are in the Full Edition (`README.md`).
>
> **You will learn:** what the LLD round is, a complete small answer, an 11-step framework with a time budget, how to get requirements and classes, a SOLID check, the six common patterns, how to write interview code, a worked parking lot, communication tips and a study plan.

1.1 What this round is, and what this handbook covers

What it is

The **low-level design (LLD)** round: design **one application** while an interviewer watches, in 45–60 minutes (machine coding: 90 min–2 h). You design **the classes inside the program** (parking lot, vending machine, chess, Splitwise), not servers. Analogy: system design is the **city plan**; LLD is the **floor plan of one house**.

Term	Meaning
Class / Object	A named type with fields and methods / one concrete instance of it
Responsibility	The one job a class does, in one sentence
Relationship	How two classes connect: uses, holds, owns, or extends
UML	Standard symbols for drawing classes and relationships
Design pattern	A named, reusable answer to a recurring design problem

The hard part is **explaining aloud** why each class exists and **justifying** how they connect.

What you should be able to do after this handbook

Bound one sentence into requirements plus an out-of-scope list; pick classes with **one job** each; relate every pair correctly; code the core flows until they run; name the pattern you used **and the one you rejected**.

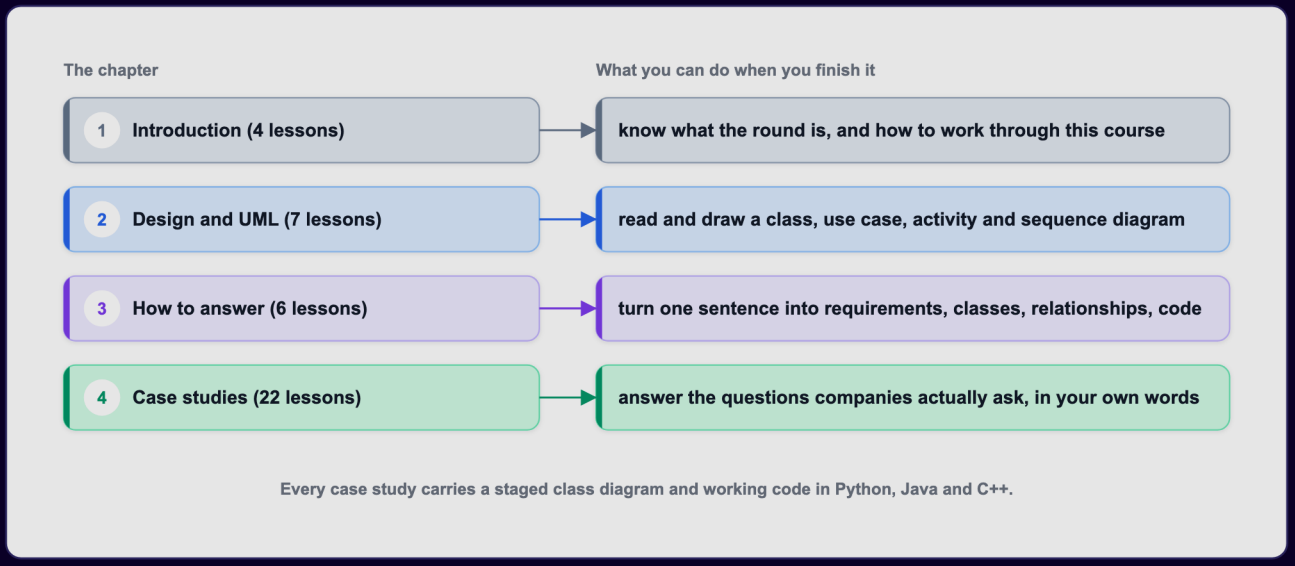


Figure — The four parts of the course material this handbook absorbs: introduction, design and UML notation, the answering method, and the case studies (course diagram)

The handbook follows this arc (round → UML → method → case studies) and adds OOP, SOLID, principles, clean code, refactoring, all 23 GoF patterns and concurrency.

What every case study in this handbook contains · Who this is for · What you need already · What this handbook will not do

- **Case-study template:** requirements with out-of-scope, actors and use cases, a staged class diagram, key flow diagrams, runnable Java with output, patterns **only where really used**, and "Extensions & follow-up questions".
- **For:** anyone facing this round. **Needed:** one OO language (examples use **Java 21**); not UML (Chapter 3), not system design (this round stays **inside one process**), not DSA beyond basic collections.
- **Won't do:** teach a language or give scripts to memorise. **The reusable part is the method.**

TL;DR

Design the classes of one application out loud, then code the main flows. Method beats memorisation.

1.2 How the interview runs

What it is

One sentence ("Design a parking lot"), then silence. Names for the round: **OOD interview** (US big tech), **LLD** (umbrella term), **machine-coding round** (commonly reported at Flipkart, Swiggy, PhonePe: **runnable code is mandatory**, 90 min–2 h).

	LLD	HLD / system design
Scope / vocabulary	One application: classes, interfaces, patterns	Many machines: servers, DBs, caches, queues
Output	Class diagram + code	Architecture + capacity numbers

OOD round vs machine-coding round

	OOD / LLD discussion	Machine coding
Time / output	45–60 min; requirements, diagram, code for 2–3 flows	~90 min coding; a **complete running program**
Storage / interaction	Rarely discussed; continuous conversation	**In-memory**; silent coding, then **demo + walkthrough**
Judged on	Bounding, responsibilities, relationships, trade-offs	Working code, **data models**, **service interfaces**, **extensibility**, readability, edge cases, sometimes thread safety
Common failure	Not converging, coding too early	Not finishing, or one giant class

How it works: the five core steps

1. **Clarify requirements** 2. **Actors and use cases** 3. **Find the classes** 4. **Connect them** (class diagram) 5. **Write the code** for 2–3 main flows.

Order matters more than speed: skip step 1 and step 3 invents classes nobody asked for.

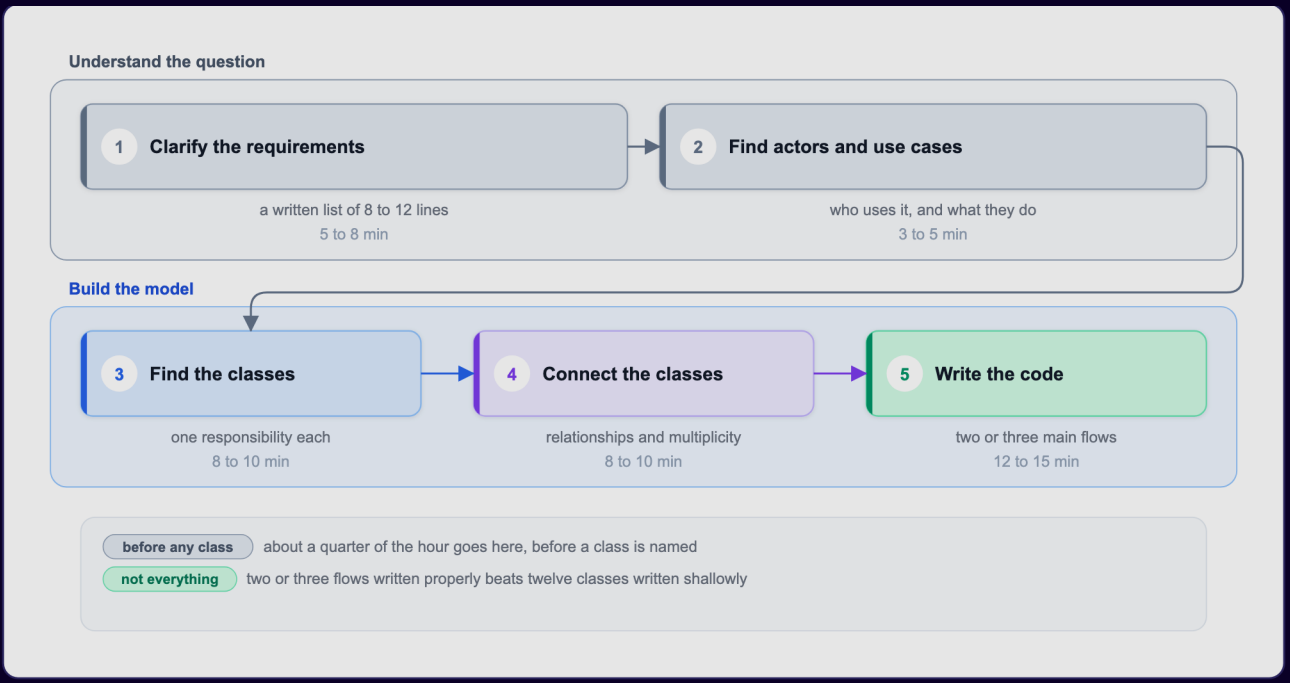


Figure – The five steps split into "understand the question" and "build the model", with a time budget for each (course diagram)

About **a quarter of the hour passes before any class is named**. **Nobody finishes the product**; you are judged on the part you built properly.

Time-boxing

45-min OOD step	Time	Output
Requirements	5–8 min	8–12 lines + out-of-scope
Actors & use cases	3–5 min	2–4 actors, 6–10 use cases
Classes	8–10 min	One responsibility each
Connect	8–10 min	Diagram with multiplicity
Code	12–15 min	2–3 main-flow methods

90-min machine coding: requirements/assumptions 5–10 · model (entities, enums, interfaces) 10–15 · core flow end to end 30–40 · remaining features + edge cases 15–20 · polish + demo 5–10 · buffer 5 (never zero). **Get something running by halfway.**

What the interviewer is actually judging

1. Did you **bound** the problem? 2. **One job** per class? 3. **Right relationships**? 4. Does **code match the diagram**? 5. Can you explain a **trade-off**?

Machine coding adds: **runs**, **modular** (new type = new class), readable, handles bad input, thread-safe (senior). Perfect UML notation is **not** graded; the model is.

A worked example of size

Parking lot: ~12 requirements → ~12 classes → ~15 relationships. Code the three that carry the main flows; name the other nine. Costliest mistake: all twelve at equal depth.

TL;DR

Five steps in order, a quarter of the time before naming a class, two or three flows done properly.

1.3 A complete answer in five minutes: "Design a music playlist"

Step 1: requirements

Songs are **ordered**; a listener asks for **the next song**; **shuffle** changes the order. **Out of scope (said aloud):** accounts, downloads, storage, audio.

Step 2: actors and use cases

One **actor** (someone outside the app): the listener (add song, play next, shuffle). On bigger problems **actors reveal which classes must exist**.

Step 3: classes, one sentence each

Class	Responsibility
`Song`	Title, artist, length; knows only itself
`Playlist`	Holds songs in order; stores, does not play
`PlayOrder` (interface)	Picks the next position (several rules exist)
`InOrder` / `Shuffled`	Insertion order / an order fixed up front
`Player`	Holds playlist + order, remembers the position

A rule that can vary becomes its own type. If a responsibility needs "and" to join two jobs, it is two classes.

Step 4: connect them

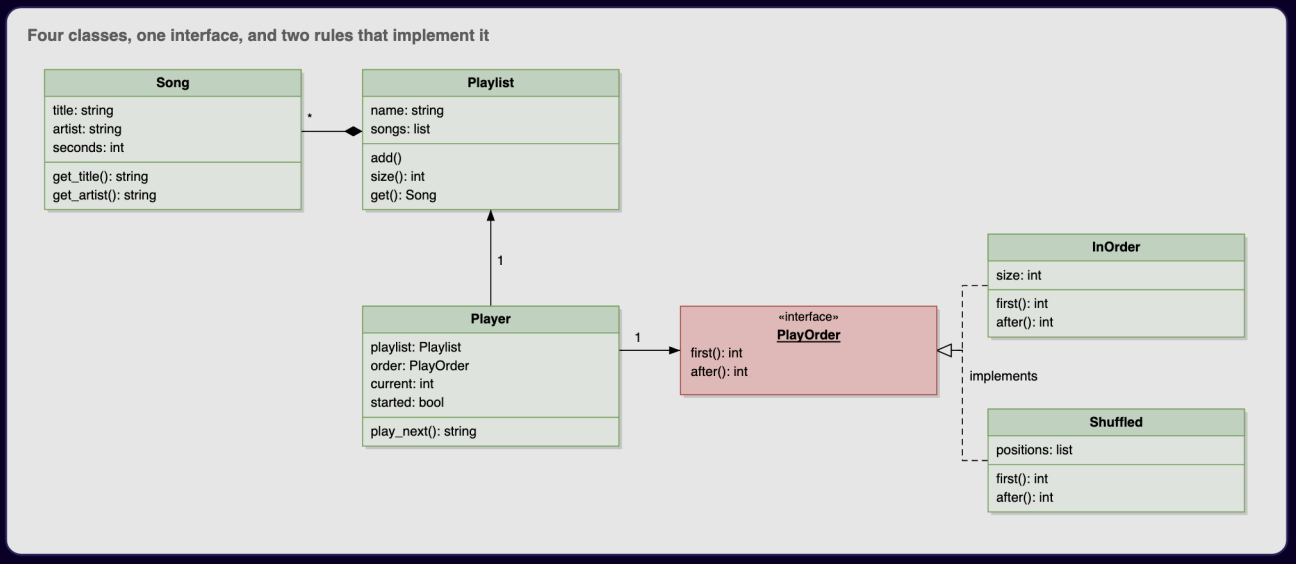
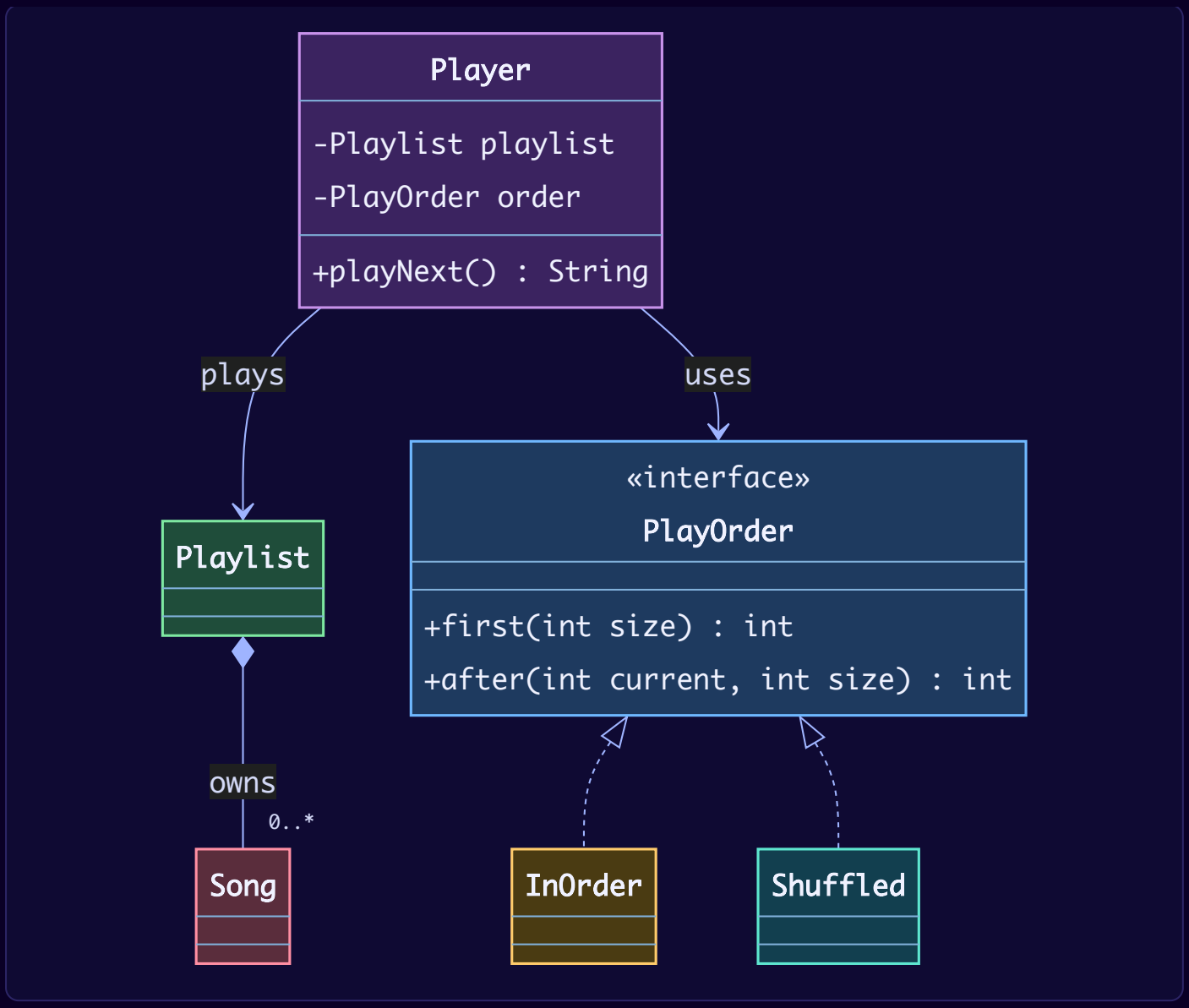


Figure — The playlist design: Playlist owns many Songs, Player uses a PlayOrder, and InOrder and Shuffled implement PlayOrder (course diagram)

Filled diamond = `Playlist` **owns** many `Song`s (composition). Plain arrow = `Player` **uses** the `PlayOrder` interface only. Dashed hollow-triangle arrows = `InOrder` / `Shuffled` **implement** it; a third rule is one more box.



Step 5: the code

```
// File: code/lld/ch01/playlist/PlayOrder.java
public interface PlayOrder {
    int NONE = -1;                          // "there is no next position"

    int first(int size);                    // first position to play, or NONE if empty
    int after(int current, int size);       // position after 'current', or NONE at the end
}
```

```java
// File: code/lld/ch01/playlist/Player.java
public final class Player {
    private final Playlist playlist;
    private final PlayOrder order;          // depends on the interface, not on InOrder/Shuffled
    private int current = PlayOrder.NONE;
    private boolean started = false;
    // ... constructor

    public String playNext() {
        if (!started) {
            current = order.first(playlist.size());
            started = true;
        } else if (current != PlayOrder.NONE) {          // once at the end, stay at the end
            current = order.after(current, playlist.size());
        }
        if (current == PlayOrder.NONE) return "end of playlist";
        Song s = playlist.get(current);
        return "playing " + s.title() + " by " + s.artist();
    }
}
```

Full runnable code: code/lld/ch01/playlist/ (see the Full Edition).

`Song` is a validating **record**; `Playlist` keeps its list `private`; `Shuffled` is **given** its order (not `Random`), so output is the same every run: **deterministic = testable**. `Player` never checks which mode is active.

What to notice

- **Shuffle (one line) became a type**: classes come from requirements.
- **One job per class**: `Song` doesn't know playlists exist.
- **Open to change**: "repeat one" is a new `PlayOrder` (Strategy + Open/Closed).
- **Announce deliberate gaps** (pause, volume, queue).

TL;DR

Bounded requirements, one-sentence classes, one diagram, code for the main flow. A varying rule becomes an interface.

1.4 The step-by-step answer framework

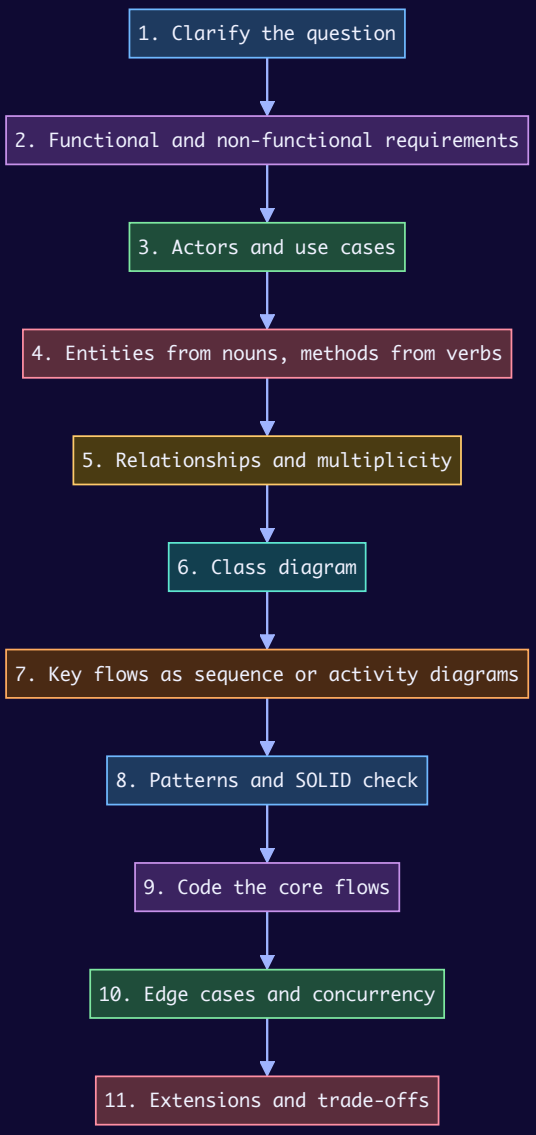
What it is

A checklist for every question, expanding the five steps into eleven.

The problem it solves

Stops freezing and premature coding; makes progress **visible** (which is scored).

How it works



Ask at step 8: varying rule (Strategy)? lifecycle (State)? many listeners (Observer)? At step 10: invalid input, full, two users on one seat?

Trade-offs

Do this	Instead of	Why
8–13 min on steps 1–3	Coding at minute 2	Unbounded scope costs more later
2–3 flows fully	12 stubs	Depth is judged
1–2 patterns with a signal	Six patterns	Over-engineering = poor judgement
Pass time in; `BigDecimal`/cents	Clock in logic; `double` money	Testable; `double` can't hold 0.10 exactly

When not to use it (rigidly)

Follow the interviewer if they steer. In machine coding, steps 5–7 are often mental; **the code is the diagram**.

TL;DR

Clarify → requirements → use cases → entities → relationships → diagram → flows → patterns/SOLID → code → edge cases → extensions. Announce each step.

1.5 From one line to a list of requirements

What it is

A **requirement** is one testable capability. **Functional** = behaviour ("customer takes a ticket"). **Non-functional** = quality (thread safety, extensibility, in-memory).

The problem it solves

Without a list the design has **no edges**, you **can't defend omissions** ("reservations were out of scope; we agreed"), and you **can't tell when you're done**.

How it works: the four questions

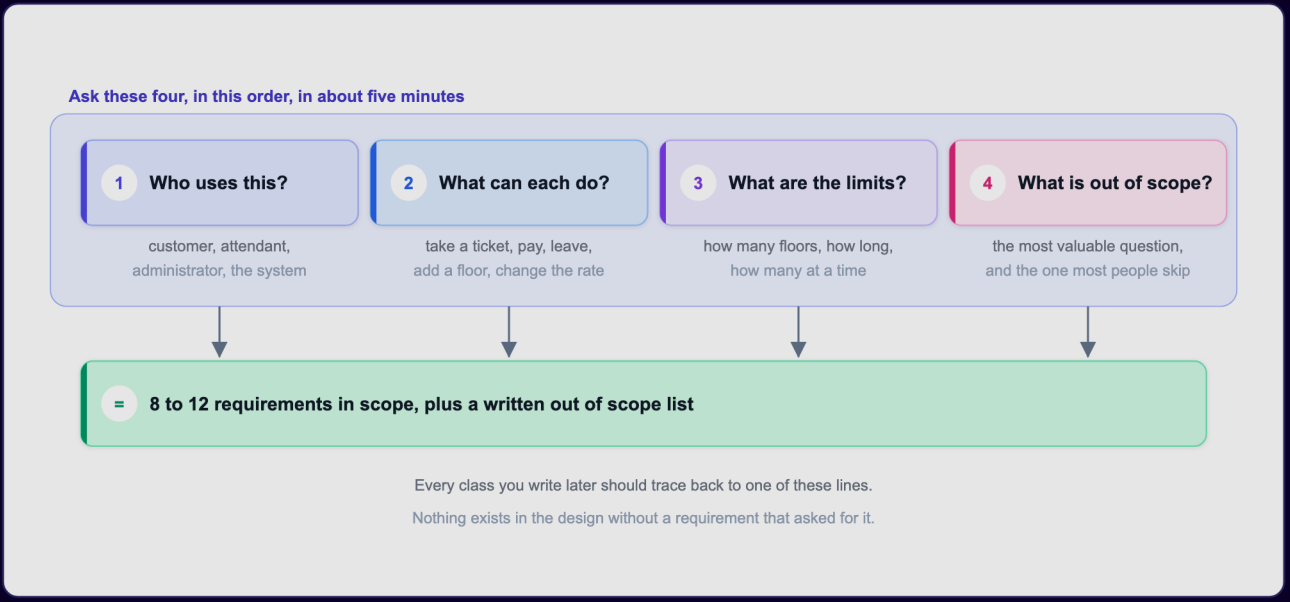


Figure – Four questions asked in order produce 8–12 in-scope requirements plus a written out-of-scope list (course diagram)

1. **Who uses it?** (actors) 2. **What can each do?** (use cases; most requirements) 3. **What are the limits?** (→ constants + validation) 4. **What is out of scope?** (the only question that makes the problem **smaller**).

Ask early: payments in scope? one site or many? users/permissions modelled? Each answer adds or removes 2–3 classes. If told "your choice": **choose, say it, write it down**.

What good looks like: the parking lot in ten lines

In scope: multiple floors of spots; spot types (compact, large, handicapped, motorbike, electric); vehicle types; ticket at entrance; pay at exit/portal/attendant; cash or card; hourly rate by stay length; free-spot display per floor; refuse entry when full; admins add floors/spots/panels and change rates. **Out of scope:** season passes, plate recognition, pre-booking, refunds, multi-site reports. **If no line asked for it, it's not in the design.**

Make each requirement checkable

Put a number on it ("at most **five** books on loan" → constant → one check) and **name the actor** ("**a member** can reserve a copy on loan" → tells you the owning class).

Use cases

Customer: take ticket, park, pay, exit. Attendant: collect cash. Admin: add floor/spot/panel, change rate. System: assign spot, update boards, refuse when full. A list is enough in 45 minutes.

Common mistakes

Saying yes to every idea (declining politely is a **strong** move); forgetting non-functional requirements; vague lines without number or actor.

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "I ask who uses it, what each actor does, the limits, and what's out of scope. I write 8–12 numbered requirements plus an out-of-scope list, confirm them, and every class must trace back to a line."

- *"Why not just start designing?"* – No boundary means endless growth and indefensible omissions.
- *"'Your choice'?"* – I pick the simpler option and write it as a visible assumption.

Self-check

- **Q:** Which question shrinks the problem? **A:** Out of scope.
- **Q:** Make "users can book some seats" checkable. **A:** "A customer can hold at most 10 seats per show; unpaid holds release after 10 minutes."

TL;DR

Who, what, limits, out of scope → 8–12 checkable lines plus out-of-scope.

1.6 Finding the classes

What it is

Collect candidates, cut non-classes, give each survivor one job.

How it works

1. **Nouns** → candidate classes (deliberately too many). 2. **Verbs** → methods; a verb with no home = a missing class. 3. **Cut with five tests:**

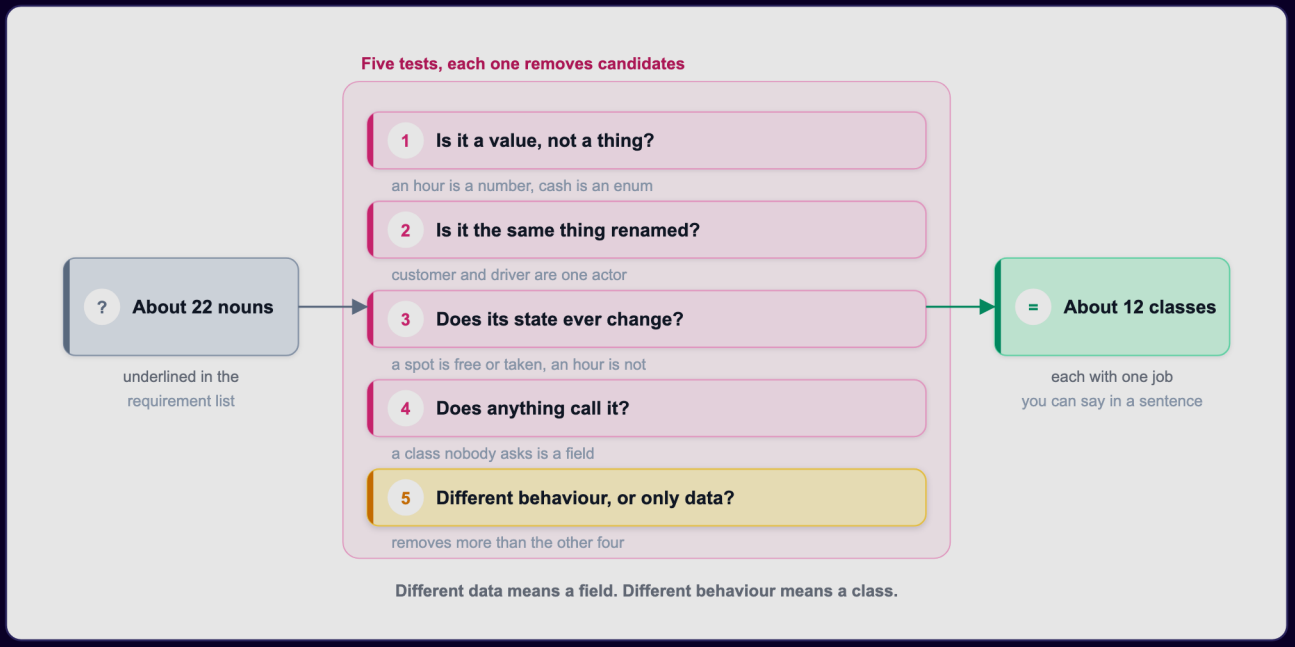


Figure – About 22 nouns pass through five tests and about 12 classes survive, each with one job (course diagram)

#	Test	Example	Result
1	A **value**?	Hour, plate, cash/card option	Field or **enum**
2	**Another name**?	Customer/driver	Merge
3	**Changing state**?	Spot free/occupied	Class
4	Anything **calls** it?	Nobody asks an `Hour`	Value
5	**Behaviour** or only **data** differs?	Compact vs large spot (data); cash vs card (behaviour)	**Data → field. Behaviour → class.**

Test 5 cuts the most: one `ParkingSpot` with a `type` field, but separate cash and card classes. Smell: subclasses that only pass a constant to the parent.

4. **One sentence per class**, e.g. `ParkingFloor` owns a level's spots and finds a free one; `ParkingSpot` tracks its occupant; `ParkingTicket` records vehicle, spot, entry time; `ParkingRate` turns duration into price; `Payment` collects money; `ParkingDisplayBoard` shows free spots. `ParkingLot` (issues tickets **and** tracks fullness) has two jobs: **name the tension aloud**.
5. **Method goes where its data is** ("find a free spot" → `ParkingFloor`). Needing three classes' data = misplaced (GRASP Information Expert; *Feature Envy*).

Common mistakes

One subclass per value; missing the **record-keeping** class (ticket/loan/booking) and the **rule** class (rate/strategy); "Manager" god classes.

Self-check

- **Q:** Car, van, truck: subclasses or enum? **A:** Enum/field unless behaviour truly differs.
- **Q:** Class with fields but no verbs? **A:** Probably a value (record/field).

TL;DR

Nouns → candidates, verbs → methods. **Different data = field; different behaviour = class.** Method where its data is.

1.7 Connecting the classes (preview)

For each pair: **uses** briefly (dependency), **holds** (association), **contains** parts that live alone (aggregation), **owns** parts that die with it (composition), or **is-a** (inheritance/realization); then **multiplicity** (1, 0..1, 1..*, *). Chapter 3 details all. Top error: inheritance where composition fits. A car is not an engine, so `Car` **has an** `Engine`.

1.8 Keeping the design honest with SOLID

What it is

The five SOLID rules (Chapter 4) used as **five quick checks** on your diagram (~5 minutes).

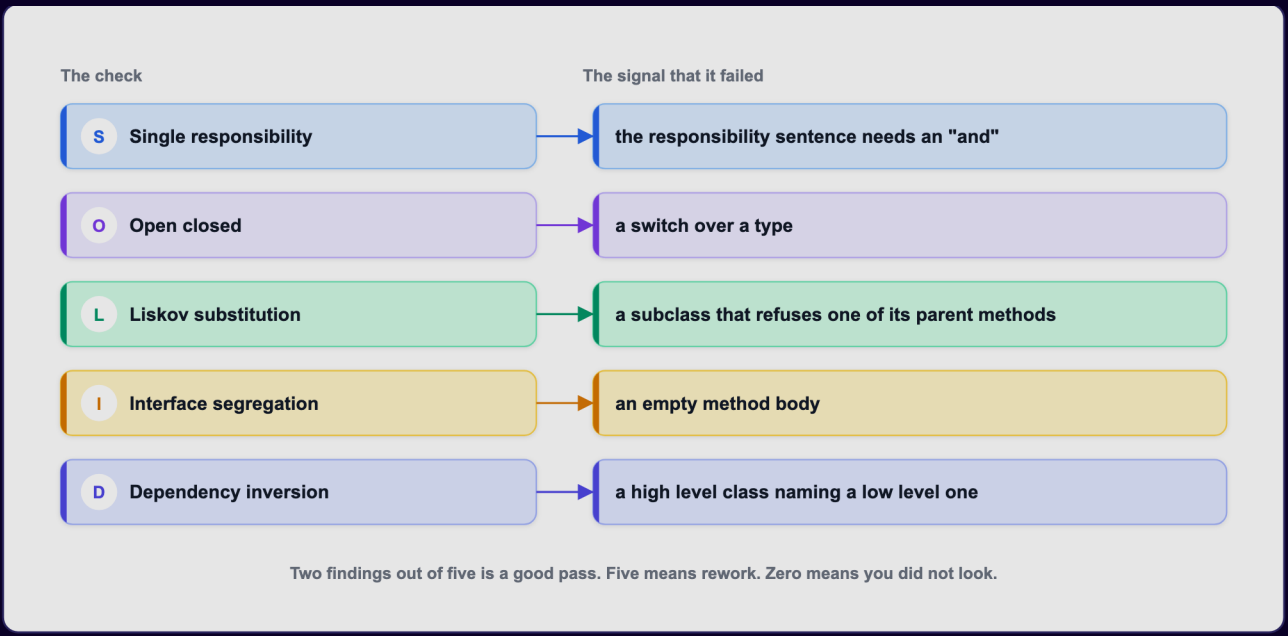


Figure — The five SOLID checks and the signal that each one has failed (course diagram)

How it works: run the five checks in this order

Check	Failure signal	Parking-lot example
S One reason to change	Sentence needs "and"	Lot that assigns spots **and** prints receipts → split
O Extend without editing	`switch` over a type	Weekend rate = new class, not new case
L Child works wherever parent does	Child throws / does nothing	`ReadOnlySpot` whose `occupy` throws
I No unused methods	Empty bodies	Split an interface half its implementers can't honour
D Depend on interfaces	High-level class does `new` of low-level	Lot depends on `Payment`, not `new CreditCardTransaction()`

The two that earn the most credit

S improves the class list; O is what gets probed ("trucks charged differently?" → "add a class").

When not to use it

No single-implementer interfaces "because SOLID" (unless a test double needs one); no splitting past what a reader can follow.

A five-minute pass over the parking lot

S: lot has two jobs (split or say it). O: pricing behind `ParkingRate`, passes. L: five behaviour-less spot subclasses aren't a Liskov violation, but they fail "different data → field": collapse. I, D: pass. **Two findings is good; five = rework; zero = you didn't look.**

TL;DR

Check S-O-L-I-D before the interviewer does; S and O matter most; don't over-apply.

1.9 The design patterns that come up in this round

What it is

A **pattern** is a named solution to a recurring problem (GoF has 23; Chapters 8–11). Six recur here. **A misapplied pattern hurts more than an unknown one**: learn the **signal**.

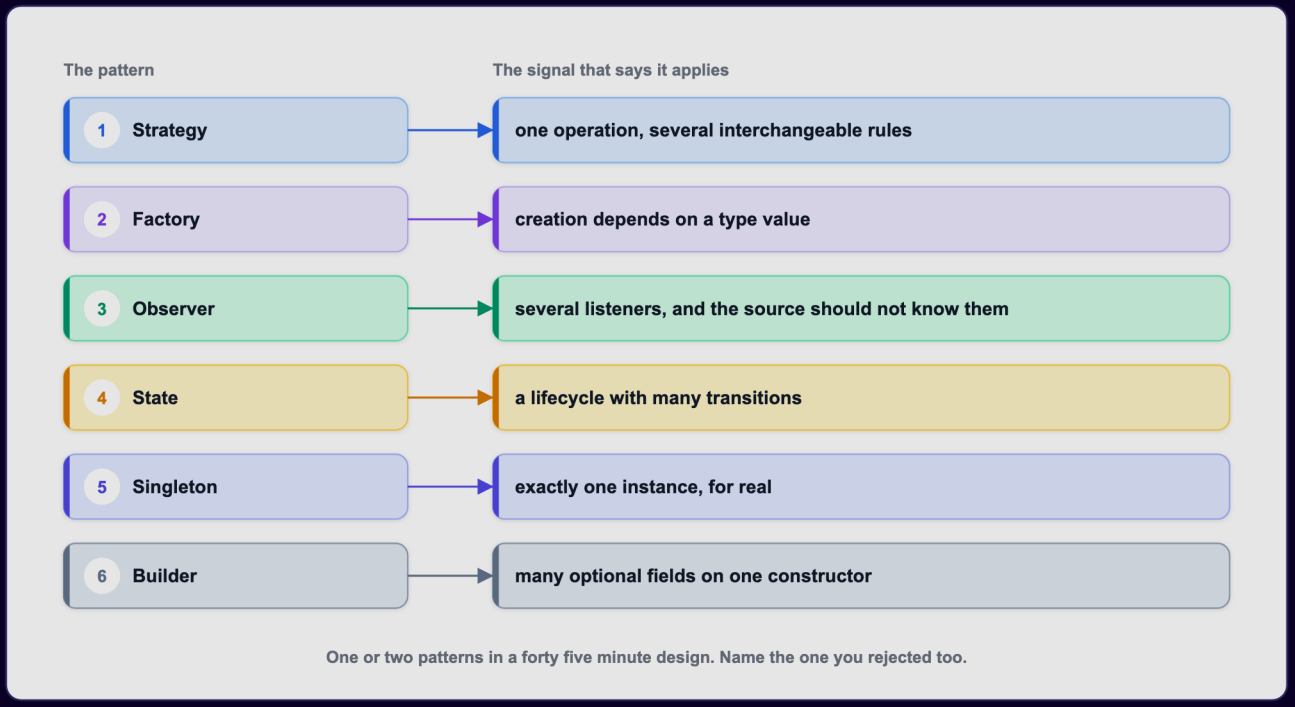


Figure – The six patterns most used in this round and the signal for each (course diagram)

What to say about each one

Pattern	Signal	What to say
Strategy	Several swappable rules for one operation	`ParkingRate` → `HourlyRate`, `WeekendRate`; a new rate is a new class, not a `switch` case
Factory	Object to build depends on a type value	Registering a new type happens in **one place**; a factory method is usually enough
Observer	One change, many listeners the source shouldn't know	The spot is the subject; boards register. One listener → direct call
State	Behaviour depends on state, fixed transitions	Illegal moves become impossible; for 3–4 states, **enum + guarded method**
Singleton	Exactly one instance	Must be **thread-safe**; **global state** hurts tests; often inject one instance instead
Builder	Many optional fields (~6+ constructor args)	Sets fields by name; a readability fix

Choosing patterns without overusing them

Skip each when its signal is absent: one rule (Strategy), one concrete class (Factory), one listener (Observer), three states and one guard (State), just wanting global access (Singleton), three required fields (Builder). **One or two patterns** per design; best is a comparison: "Rate gets Strategy; ticket doesn't get State, one guard covers three statuses."

Real-world examples

`Comparator` (Strategy); `List.of`, `Executors.newFixedThreadPool` (Factory); `ActionListener`, Spring events (Observer); order lifecycle, TCP (State); `Runtime.getRuntime()` (Singleton; Spring beans are singleton **per**

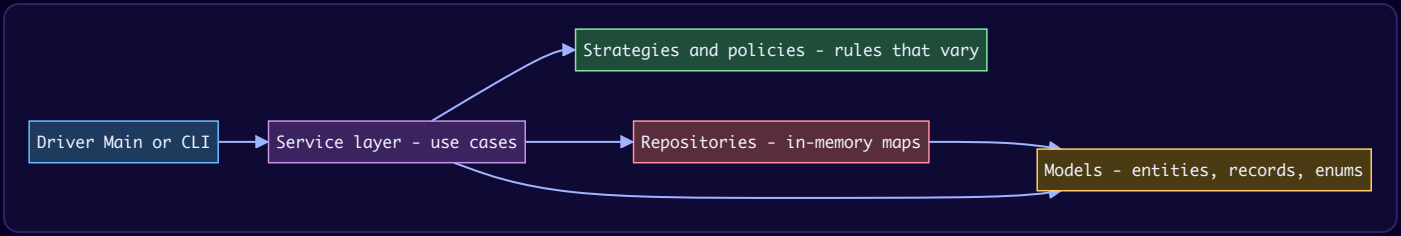
container); `StringBuilder`, `HttpRequest.newBuilder()` (Builder).

TL;DR

Know six; use one or two where the signal appears; name the rejected one.

1.10 Code, edge cases and concurrency: how to write interview code

How it works: a machine-coding skeleton that scales



Models (validated entities, records, enums) → **repositories** (in-memory maps behind an interface) → **strategies** (rules that vary) → **services** (use cases: the **service interface**) → **driver** (`Main` demo).

Habits: pass time in; money as `BigDecimal` (from strings) or cents, never `double`; fail loudly (`IllegalArgumentException`, `IllegalStateException`, clear custom exceptions); `Optional` for normal "not found"; `private final` fields; domain names.

Edge cases and concurrency checklist

Input (null, negative, duplicate/unknown IDs) · **Capacity** (full lot, empty playlist) · **State** (pay twice, exit without entry) · **Time** (exit before entry, round part hours) · **Concurrency** (two threads, same seat: `synchronized`, `ReentrantLock`, `ConcurrentHashMap.computeIfAbsent`; lock the **smallest** thing that keeps the invariant; Chapters 12–13).

TL;DR

Models → repositories → strategies → services → driver; inject time, exact money, validate, guard shared state.

1.11 Worked mini-example, end to end: a small parking lot

Problem & clarifying questions

Assumed answers: single lot, one or more floors; motorbike/car/truck; MOTORBIKE/COMPACT/LARGE spots (smaller vehicles may use bigger spots); payment out of scope (we compute the fee); tiered hourly pricing, swappable; several panels act concurrently.

Requirements

1. Floors with MOTORBIKE, COMPACT, LARGE spots. 2. Motorbike → MOTORBIKE/COMPACT; car → COMPACT/LARGE; truck → LARGE; smallest first. 3. Entry assigns a spot and issues a ticket. 4. No fit → refused. 5. Exit closes ticket, frees spot, returns fee. 6. $4.00 first hour, $3.50 hours 2–3, $2.50 after; round up; minimum 1 h; trucks double. 7. Pricing swappable at run time (flat $10 weekend). 8. Free-spot count per type.

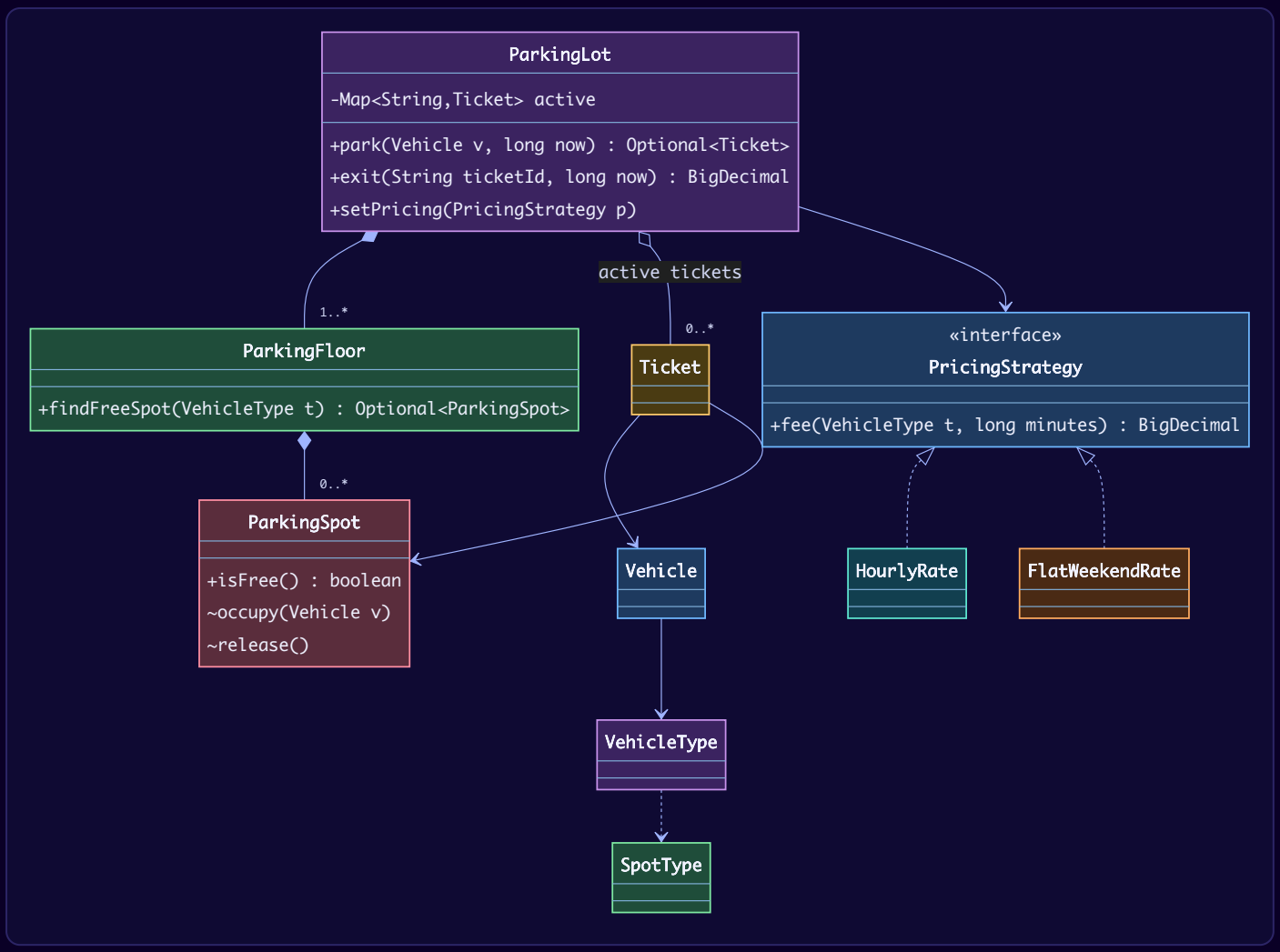
Non-functional: in-memory, thread-safe, extensible, time passed in. **Out of scope:** payment collection, reservations, boards, plate recognition, multiple lots.

Use cases · Core entities

Driver: enter/exit. Admin: add spots, change pricing. System: find spot, refuse, compute fee. Types: `SpotType`, `VehicleType` (enums; vehicle knows which spots fit), `Vehicle` and `Ticket` (records; the ticket is

the "connection object"), `ParkingSpot`, `ParkingFloor`, `PricingStrategy` + `HourlyRate` / `FlatWeekendRate`, and `ParkingLot` (the service). Spot sizes are an enum: **different data → field**.

Class diagram



Key flows

`park`: lot asks each floor `findFreeSpot(type)`; if found, `occupy` it and return a `Ticket`, else return empty (refuse). `exit`: remove the ticket, `release()` the spot, return `pricing.fee(type, minutes)`.

Design decisions & patterns used

Decision	Why	Rejected
Strategy pricing	Weekend rule required; open/closed	`switch` in the lot
Enums for types	Data only differs	Subclass per type
`Ticket` record	Fixed after issue (only *shallowly* immutable)	Mutable ticket
`BigDecimal`	`3.50 + 3.50` is exactly `7.00`	`double`
`synchronized` lot methods	Two panels never share a spot	Per-floor locks (extension)
No Singleton, no State	Injectable/testable; only active/closed	`getInstance()`; state classes

Java implementation

```java
// File: code/lld/ch01/parkinglot/HourlyRate.java
public final class HourlyRate implements PricingStrategy {
    // ... FIRST_HOUR = 4.00, HOURS_2_TO_3 = 3.50, LATER_HOURS = 2.50
    @Override
    public BigDecimal fee(VehicleType type, long minutesParked) {
        long hours = Math.max(1, (minutesParked + 59) / 60);    // ceiling, minimum one hour
        BigDecimal total = BigDecimal.ZERO;
        for (long h = 1; h <= hours; h++) {
            total = total.add(h == 1 ? FIRST_HOUR : (h <= 3 ? HOURS_2_TO_3 : LATER_HOURS));
        }
        return type == VehicleType.TRUCK ? total.multiply(BigDecimal.TWO) : total;
    }
}
```

```java
// File: code/lld/ch01/parkinglot/ParkingLot.java
public final class ParkingLot {
    private final Map<String, Ticket> active = new HashMap<>();
    private PricingStrategy pricing;
    // ... floors, nextTicket, constructor

    public synchronized Optional<Ticket> park(Vehicle v, long nowMinute) {
        for (ParkingFloor floor : floors) {
            Optional<ParkingSpot> spot = floor.findFreeSpot(v.type());
            if (spot.isPresent()) {
                spot.get().occupy(v);
                Ticket t = new Ticket("T" + nextTicket++, v, spot.get(), nowMinute);
                active.put(t.id(), t);
                return Optional.of(t);
            }
        }
        return Optional.empty();              // lot full for this vehicle type -> refuse entry
    }

    public synchronized BigDecimal exit(String ticketId, long nowMinute) {
        Ticket t = active.get(ticketId);
        if (t == null) throw new IllegalArgumentException("unknown or already closed ticket " + ticketId);
        if (nowMinute < t.entryMinute()) throw new IllegalArgumentException("exit before entry");
        active.remove(ticketId);               // validate first, then change state
        t.spot().release();
        return pricing.fee(t.vehicle().type(), nowMinute - t.entryMinute());
    }
    // ... freeSpots(type) and setPricing(p), both synchronized
}
```

Full runnable code: code/lld/ch01/parkinglot/ (see the Full Edition).

Output (excerpt): the third car is refused; `T1 exits after 150 min, pays $11.00` (4.00 + 3.50 + 3.50); the truck's 50 min → 1 h × 2 = `$8.00`; after `setPricing(new FlatWeekendRate())` the exit pays `$10.00`; a second exit of T1 prints `error: unknown or already closed ticket T1`.

Concurrency & edge cases

`synchronized park/exit` makes find-then-occupy **atomic** (no *check-then-act* race); `freeSpots` uses the same lock; `ParkingFloor` is only called under it. `exit` **validates before changing state**; `occupy` throws if taken (second defence) and is package-private.

Extensions & follow-up questions

- **EV charging:** `ELECTRIC` spot + `ELECTRIC_CAR`; if charging has behaviour, a `ChargingSpot` or composed component.
- **Nearest spot:** inject a `SpotSelectionStrategy`.
- **Display boards:** Observer on spot events.

- **Throughput:** per-floor/type locks, or a `ConcurrentLinkedQueue` of free spots with atomic `poll()`.
- **Cash/card:** `Payment` interface + implementations, collected by a `PaymentService` (DIP).

In the interview

~5 min requirements, 3 actors, 8 entities (enum vs subclass), 8 diagram, 15 coding `park`, `exit`, `HourlyRate`. Close by naming Strategy (used), Singleton and State (rejected), and per-floor locking.

Self-check

- **Q:** What race does `synchronized park` prevent? **A:** Two threads occupying the same free spot.
- **Q:** How did the weekend rate respect open/closed? **A:** A new class; nothing edited.

TL;DR

8 requirements, 10 types, one Strategy, one lock, an honest out-of-scope list.

1.12 Communication tips

Do: think out loud (name the step), write requirements/classes where visible, confirm before moving on, state assumptions, give trade-offs in pairs ("X over Y because..."), welcome hints, say what you leave out, watch the clock and announce the switch to code, use domain names (not `Manager` / `Helper`), and **when stuck, return to the requirements**. **Don't:** go silent, argue, talk `HashMap`s in minute two, or recite patterns without a reason.

1.13 How to use this handbook, and a study plan

Attempt first, then compare

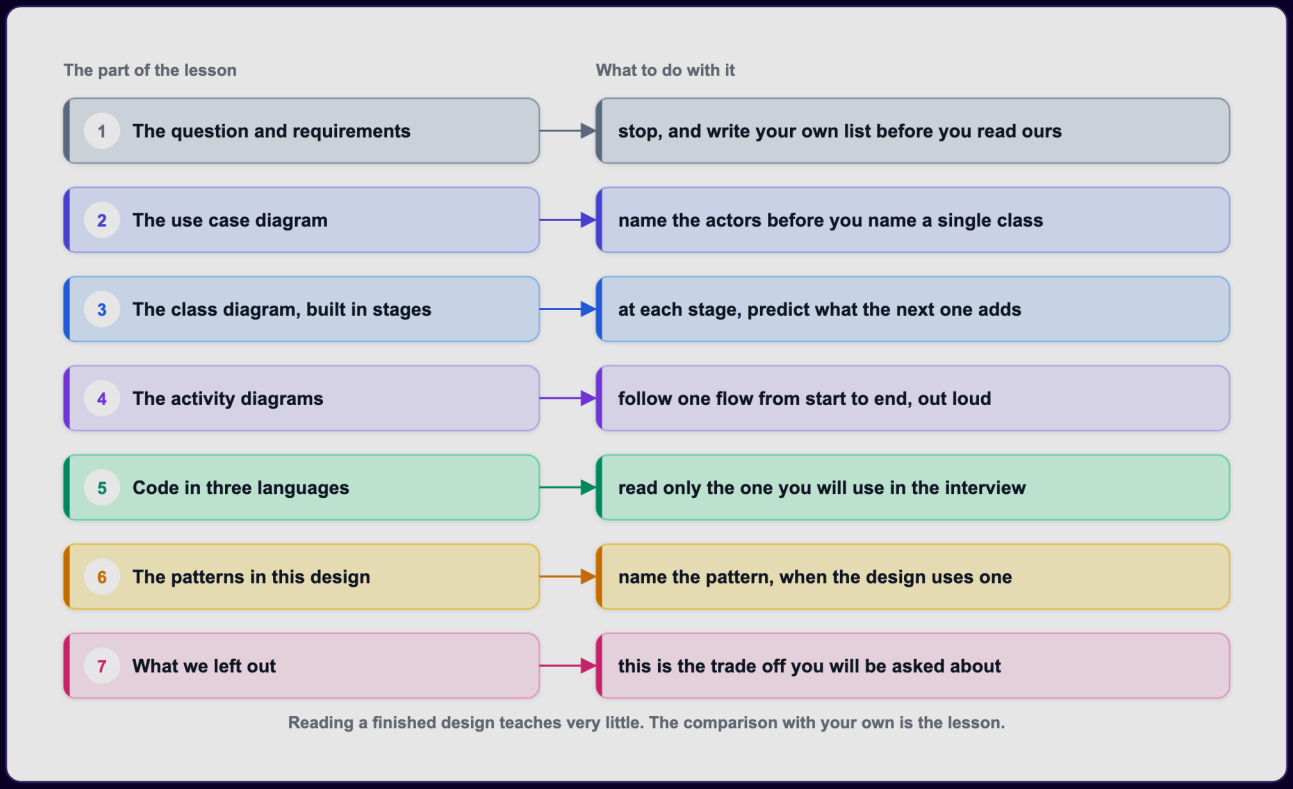


Figure – The parts of a case-study lesson and what to do at each one (course diagram)

Reading builds little skill; **attempt, then compare**. Stop (1) after the question (write requirements), (2) after the requirements (write classes; most people are **two short**: the record class and the rule class), (3) at each diagram stage (predict). Also: argue with decisions in writing, read one language, **never skip extensions**,

don't invent pattern names, switch to **timed 45-minute blank-page runs** after 6–7 case studies, run `bash tools/compile_all.sh`.

Map of this handbook

1 approach · 2 OOP · 3 relationships & UML · 4 SOLID · 5 design principles · 6 clean code · 7 refactoring · 8 creational · 9 structural · 10–11 behavioural (+MVC) · 12 concurrency concepts · 13 concurrency problems · 14 everyday objects · 15–16 booking & inventory · 17 games · 18–19 platforms · 20 components (LRU, rate limiter, Splitwise) · 21 machine coding · 22 cheat sheets.

Study plans

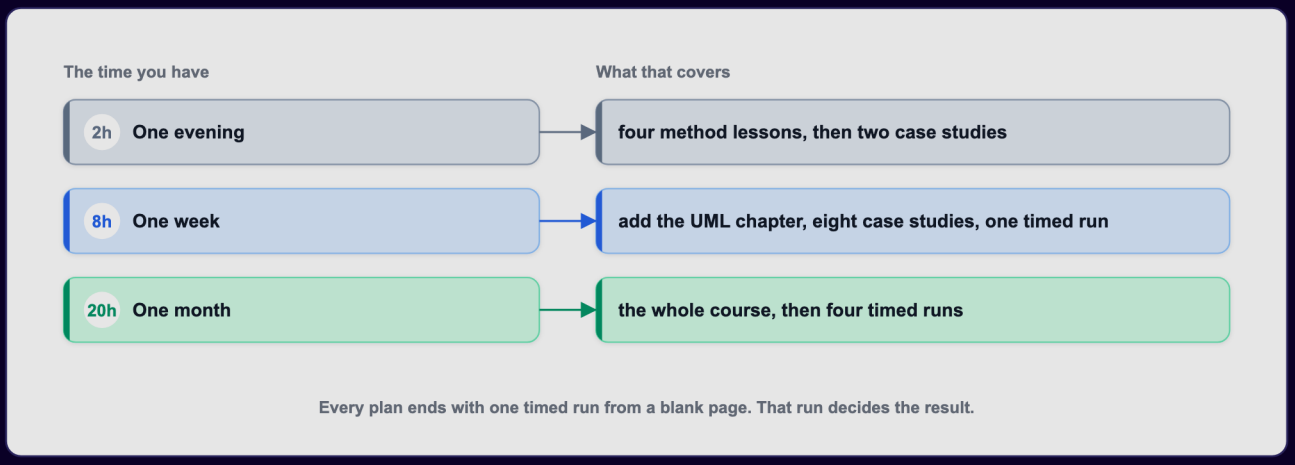


Figure – Three study plans for three amounts of time; every plan ends with one timed run from a blank page (course diagram)

- **Tomorrow (~2 h):** §1.2, §1.5, §1.6, Ch 3 relationship guide + class notation, parking lot (30 min), vending machine (25 min, a **lifecycle**).
- **One week:** Ch 1 + OOP pillars; Ch 3 diagrams; parking lot + library; ATM + vending; movie tickets + hotel; Splitwise + Amazon; **day 7: redo parking lot blank-page in 45 min**.
- **One month (~20 h):** Ch 1–4 + 3 case studies; Ch 5, 8–11 + case studies 4–10; Ch 12–13 + 11–18 + a timed run; the rest, Ch 21, three timed runs, Ch 22.
- **Beginner (6 weeks):** Ch 1–2; 3–5; 6–8; 9–11 + two case studies; 12–13 + four incl. ticket booking; Ch 21 timed runs + Ch 22.

Only six case studies? Parking lot, library, vending machine, movie tickets (concurrency), Splitwise (money), Amazon (too big: choose). Add **LRU cache** if data-structure questions are likely. **Night before:** nothing new; re-read the time budget; recite **requirements, actors and use cases, classes, relationships, code.**

1.14 Common mistakes

Mistake	Fix
Coding in minute two; no out-of-scope list; yes to every feature	8–13 min on requirements; write and agree scope
One subclass per value; god class	Data → field/enum; split on "and"
Missing record class; "Car extends Engine"	Connection with data = object; composition
Pattern stuffing; `switch` on type	1–2 patterns with signal; polymorphism
Equal depth everywhere; silent designing	2–3 flows fully; narrate
Ignoring concurrency; non-running code	Lock shared state; thin path running by halfway
`double` money; clock in logic	`BigDecimal`/cents; inject time

In the interview

30-second answer: "I clarify and write 8–12 requirements with an out-of-scope list, list actors and use cases, pick classes from the nouns with one responsibility each, connect them in a class diagram, sketch the key flow, run a SOLID check and pick one or two patterns where the signal is clear. Then I code the core flows, handle edge cases and concurrency, and finish with extensions and trade-offs."

- *"Different from system design?"* – That's many machines and scale; LLD is classes and code inside one application.
- *"You won't finish; what matters?"* – Bounded scope, clean responsibilities, correct relationships, code matching the diagram, one defended trade-off.

Self-check

- **Q:** Five core steps? **A:** Requirements, actors & use cases, classes, relationships, code.
- **Q:** Two classes beginners miss? **A:** The record-keeping class and the rule class.
- **Q:** Patterns in 45 minutes? **A:** One or two where the signal appears; name a rejected one.

TL;DR

- Design the classes of one app and code main flows; machine coding = same, running, ~90 min.
- A quarter of the time before naming a class; always an out-of-scope list.
- Different data → field; different behaviour → class; one sentence per class.
- SOLID as quick checks; one or two patterns with a signal.
- Inject time, exact money, guard shared state; attempt first, then timed blank-page runs.